

What else to watch: *Vertigo* (1958, pp.140–45) ■ *Infernal Affairs* (1990) ■ *Sympathy for Mr. Vengeance* (2002) ■ *Sympathy for Lady Vengeance* (2005) ■ *Mother* (2009) ■ *Thirst* (2009) ■ *Stoker* (2013)



find that his imprisonment had itself been designed to avenge an old wrong.

Blood opera

Perhaps *Oldboy*'s most vital ingredient is a stylistic and technical artistry that serves as a counterpoint to the movie's violence. The director achieves this in a number of ways.

First, the sound track is highly

orchestral. One gruesome sequence is accompanied by the Baroque chamber music of Vivaldi's "Four Seasons." The original score, by Jo Yeong-wook, is also classical in style. This creates a grandiose, operatic feel that elevates the story above the violence. The same is achieved visually, too, most memorably in a remarkable special effect in which the camera pans around Oh Dae-su in his prison cell, and his face appears almost to vibrate out of its skin, as if his mind

Oh Dae-su attacks the guards of the prison where he has been held captive for 15 years. The long fight scene was filmed as one continuous shot.

is trying to break free from his body. The director forgoes realism in order to communicate the character's emotional state.

A similar stepping-out-of-reality occurs at the end, when we see an elaborate flashback to the events we now realize sparked the story into life. Visually, key characters should be young—but no, they look exactly the same as they do in the present, *Oldboy* suggesting that they never escaped the trauma of their past. (Do any of us, the movie asks?)

Hi-tech violence

South Korean movies at the turn of the century became noted for their violence, but what has been less noticed is the technical artistry that accompanies them. This was never more aptly represented than in *Oldboy*, a movie that is certainly brutal, but high-mindedly disturbs as much as it viscerally shocks, a revenge movie for both the connoisseur and the gore hound. ■



Park Chan-wook Director

Park Chan-wook was born in Seoul, South Korea, in 1963.

While studying philosophy at college, he discovered a love of film, and started a film studies group called the Sogang Fil Community. After graduating, he wrote for movie journals before becoming an assistant director. His first

movie was *The Moon Is the Sun's Dream* (1992). This was not a success and it was five years before Park got his next chance to direct. He is best known for his *Vengeance* trilogy.

Key movies

2003 *Oldboy*
2009 *Thirst*
2013 *Stoker*